

Generate candidates before committing

Thinking And Training

THE IDEA

A candidate move is a serious option worth calculating. Begin with forcing moves and the opponent's threats, then add a quiet improvement when appropriate. Comparing two or three plausible ideas is often more effective than calculating the first attractive move deeply.

WORKED EXAMPLE

You see a tempting capture, but a checking move may gain a more valuable piece. Listing both before calculation prevents the first idea from monopolizing your attention. The best candidate may still be the quiet defensive move.

TRY IT BEFORE READING ON

When should candidate generation be short?

ANSWER AND REASONING

When you are in check or a forcing threat limits the legal answers. Even then, inspect all reasonable defenses before committing. The goal is useful alternatives, not a fixed number of moves.

TAKE THIS INTO YOUR NEXT GAME

Give a good-looking move a competitor.